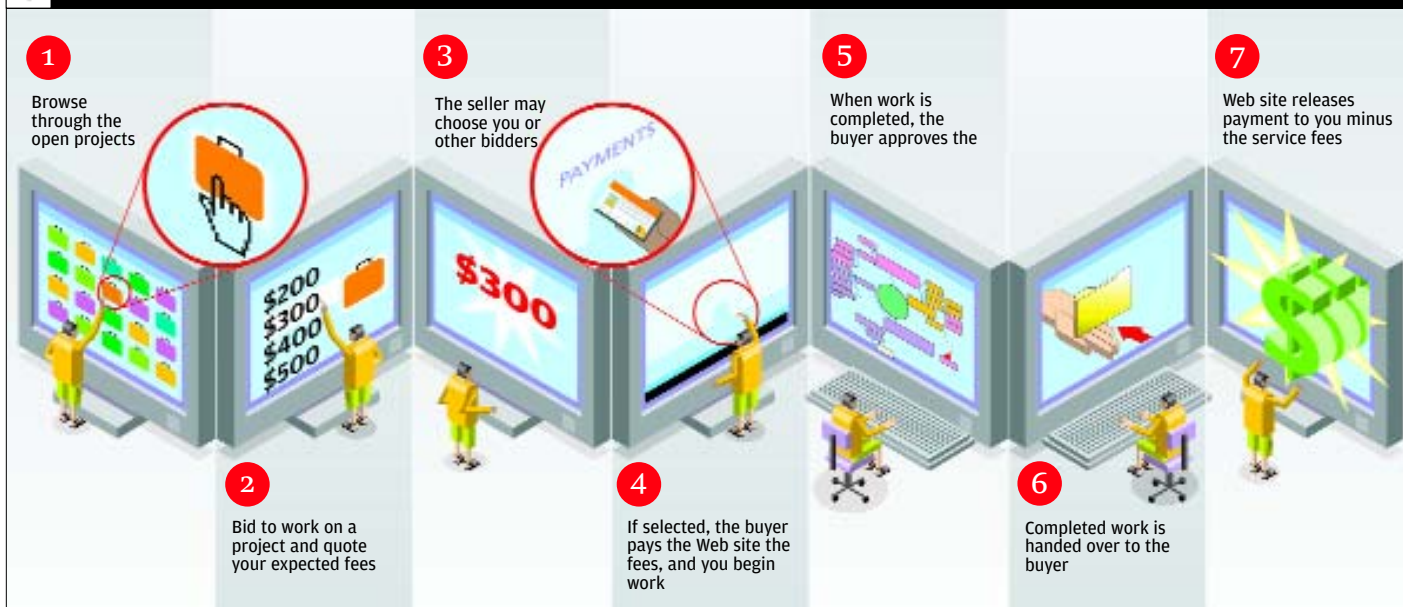


How it Works



Graphics: Solomon Lewis

all over the world.

It is not easy getting a project, though. For every assignment, there are likely to be several bidders, and the experience each time may not be a pleasant one. Says Gupta, "Getting projects on Elance Online is a mixed bag. Because the client is on the other side of the world, and we never meet, it does create issues at times."

The process, although seemingly easy, is not fixed; it varies from project to project, and most

Not that Elance Online is the only site that caters to freelancers from across the world. For software programmers and creative professionals, sites such as Guru.com and rentacoder.com have been around for ages. Guru.com, for instance, has a tie-up with remit2india.com where you can collect payments from clients abroad. Rentacoder is free, but is restricted to small projects that could be executed by individual programmers. This is one reason

why Synapse does not bid on rentacoder.com.

On Elance Online, the cost of bidding could be quite high, even if the returns over a period could be higher. Prices range from \$12 (Rs 560) a month for writing and translation assignments to \$1,195 (Rs 56,000) a year for software, technology, design and engineering categories. In addition, there is an 8.75 per cent service charge. Besides,

even if the first wire transfer of funds is free, each incremental transaction would set you back by \$10. This pricing mechanism allows Elance Online to keep the site free of any riffraff, although there are still some who do not honour their commitments.

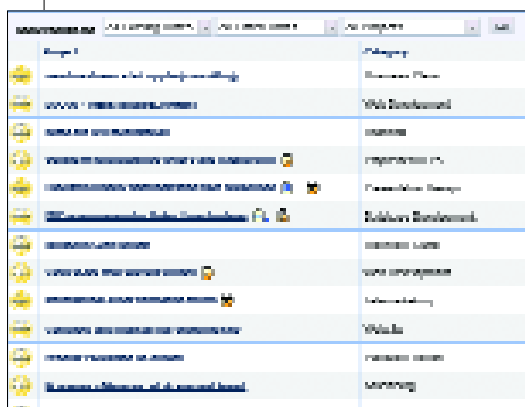
Another problem, as Gupta points out, is that Elance

requires that payments be routed through them. "But Elance does not provide any guarantees since they simply act as a common meeting ground between the service providers and the buyers. About 40 per cent of payments on Elance result in defaults."

Elance is all about open opportunities. There is no hard and fast rule to get a project. You need to keep on striving.

Kapil Gupta

COO, Synapse Communications Pvt. Ltd.
Used Elance.com to jumpstart his business



Choose from a variety of projects from different fields

times you end up disappointed as the project may be awarded to someone else. Your experience at Elance itself counts, and it usually takes that one breakthrough to get you set. As Gupta says: "Each project and each client is different. There is no single way that can describe the steps from start to finish."

On the positive side, however, the site offers a well-defined selection of the most popular job categories—from photography to developing .Net applications. And since most of the work is done through the Net without any human interaction, it does not really matter how educated you are, or how big your company is, as long as your work is credible and is of the highest quality.

Indians, especially, love this site because western project managers tend to give big projects to Indians, because they quote rates that are 50-70 per cent lower than their American counterparts for the same quality of work, if not better. Sounds familiar? The outsourcing debate just got a new point■

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